

Project Wayfinder — Thematic Update: The Exploration Society

Revised Core Fantasy

The player is no longer simply the Chief Cartographer or Quartermaster of an expedition.

Instead, they are **the newly appointed Director of a small, underfunded Exploration Society** during an alternate Victorian era in which an immense newly discovered frontier has become the focus of scientific curiosity, national pride, and international competition.

The Society begins as an obscure organization with limited funding, inexperienced personnel, and little political influence. Rival organizations—such as royal geographic societies, universities, commercial expeditions, and imperial governments—are already establishing their reputations.

The player's objective is not merely to reveal the map.

Their objective is to transform their society into the world's premier institution of exploration.

Every expedition is another chapter in that story.

Updated Core Fantasy

Project Wayfinder is a game about **building the legacy of an exploration society**.

The player never controls explorers directly.

Instead, they serve as the Society's director:

- selecting expedition objectives
- assembling expedition teams
- allocating funding
- establishing exploration doctrine
- interpreting expedition reports
- deciding where to establish permanent outposts
- investing discoveries back into the organization

The explorers are the Society's representatives in the field.

The Society is the true protagonist.

Prestige

Prestige becomes the Society's primary long-term measure of success.

Unlike funding, prestige is permanent.

Prestige represents the world's confidence in the Society.

It reflects:

- scientific reputation
- public admiration
- government confidence
- investor trust
- academic recognition
- diplomatic influence

Successful expeditions increase prestige by:

- discovering new regions
- being the first to reach important landmarks
- returning valuable artifacts
- documenting unknown cultures
- publishing scientific discoveries
- successfully completing prestigious commissions

Failed expeditions may reduce prestige, especially when avoidable mistakes or catastrophic losses become public.

Prestige should primarily function as **a narrative measure of institutional growth**, rather than another currency. (Any interaction with future progression systems or research trees is intentionally left undecided.)

Expedition Rewards

Each expedition contributes to several aspects of the Society.

Typical rewards include:

- Funding
- Prestige
- Scientific discoveries
- Cultural knowledge
- Museum artifacts
- Survey data

- Candidate outpost locations

Rather than simply earning "loot," expeditions expand the Society's influence and understanding of the frontier.

Headquarters

The headquarters represents the Society itself.

As prestige grows, headquarters expands into an increasingly respected institution.

Departments may eventually include:

- Museum Wing
- Geographic Survey Office
- Scientific Academy
- Anthropological Society
- Engineering Corps

These departments represent the growing capabilities of the Society rather than abstract player upgrades.

Museum Collections

Artifacts recovered during expeditions become part of the Society's permanent collection.

Rare discoveries become famous exhibits that increase the Society's reputation and help attract:

- visitors
- investors
- researchers
- wealthy patrons
- talented explorers

Each major artifact should feel like a historic achievement rather than a collectible item.

Rival Exploration Societies

The player is not alone.

Throughout the campaign, competing exploration organizations continue launching expeditions into the frontier.

They may:

- discover landmarks first
- establish outposts
- make scientific breakthroughs
- negotiate with indigenous cultures
- compete for government contracts

These rivals create organic pressure without relying on artificial timers.

History continues whether or not the player succeeds.

The Importance of Discovery

Victorian exploration was driven by the desire to be first.

Project Wayfinder embraces this philosophy.

Examples include:

- First ascent of a mountain range.
- First documented contact with a tribe.
- First complete crossing of a desert.
- First discovery of an ancient ruin.
- First charting of a river system.
- First successful portal expedition.

Being first creates permanent prestige and establishes the Society's legacy.

Expedition Reports & Newspapers

The conclusion of an expedition should feel like the Society returning home to present its achievements to the world.

Instead of only showing statistics, expedition summaries can be framed through newspapers, scientific journals, investor reports, and public announcements.

Examples:

"The Wayfinder Society Discovers the Crystal Sea"

"Investors Praise Successful Southern Expedition"

"Expedition Lost in the Emerald Jungle"

These reports reinforce that the player's actions shape the reputation and history of an institution, not merely the outcome of an isolated roguelike run.

Overall Design Philosophy

Every mechanic should reinforce a single fantasy:

The player is not exploring the frontier.

They are building the institution that will become synonymous with exploring it.